

Comparison Report: Three Iconic Archived Websites

Prepared using publicly available information from the Internet Archive's Wayback Machine and web design history sources
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1. Overview

This report compares three of the most recognizable websites of the early internet era, as preserved in the Internet Archive's Wayback Machine and documented by web-design history sources: **Google.com (1998)**, **Yahoo.com (1996)**, and **Amazon.com (1995)**. Each represents a different pillar of the early commercial web — search, portal/directory, and e-commerce — making them a useful and highly familiar cross-section of how the web looked in its formative years.

	Google.com	Yahoo.com	Amazon.com
Category	Search engine	Web directory / portal	Online retailer
Year archived	1998	1996	1995
Founders	Larry Page & Sergey Brin	Jerry Yang & David Filo	Jeff Bezos
Status today	Evolved continuously; the 1998 look survives only as an Easter egg	Evolved continuously through many redesigns	Evolved continuously into a global marketplace

2. Individual Profiles

2.1 Google.com (1998)

Google began as a Stanford research project by `<cite index="9-1">Larry Page and Sergey Brin, who were PhD students at Stanford University in California</cite>`. The earliest archived homepage was extremely bare: `<cite index="9-1">a welcome message with two web links, the first pointing to the original search engine prototype hosted on Stanford's own subdomain</cite>`. By late 1998 the site had grown slightly more cluttered, and `<cite index="10-1">it still leaned on its academic roots, with prominent emphasis on "Stanford Search" and a subscription link for the now-discontinued Google Friends newsletter, all under a "Beta" label and a logo its co-founder had made in an image editor</cite>`. `<cite index="2-1">Google itself only became a company in September 1998</cite>`, so the archived pages capture the exact transition from research prototype to commercial product.

- **Design language:** Plain HTML, minimal color, no imagery beyond the logo — function over form.
- **Core purpose:** Deliver relevant search results via the (at the time novel) PageRank algorithm.

- **Notable trivia:** Google later turned this era into a permanent nostalgia feature; <cite index="6-1">typing "Google in 1998" into today's search bar triggers an Easter egg that recreates the original interface</cite>.

2.2 Yahoo.com (1996)

Yahoo's earliest archived pages show a service oriented around browsing rather than searching. <cite index="11-1">The 1996 homepage centered on a simple hierarchical directory, along with news headlines, an "Add Your URL" submission link, a "Cool Sites" feature, and directory search</cite>. Unlike Google, Yahoo was building a broad portal from day one — <cite index="11-1">core offerings such as local business listings and maps, news, stock information, directory-based search, and sports have been part of the site since its earliest days</cite>.

- **Design language:** Text-heavy, categorized link lists; visually similar to a table of contents.
- **Core purpose:** Human-curated directory of the web, expanding quickly into a general portal.
- **Notable trivia:** Independent trackers have compiled visual timelines showing Yahoo's homepage evolving year-by-year from 1996 through the mid-2000s, making it one of the best-documented sites in web design history.

2.3 Amazon.com (1995)

Amazon launched in July 1995 as, in its own words, "Earth's biggest bookstore." <cite index="29-1">The original logo featured an abstract letter "A" with a winding river running through it, and the color scheme was typical for the time — mostly gray tones without much vibrancy</cite>. <cite index="29-1">The company offered more than a million book titles, far outpacing any competitor, and included a simple search tool to help visitors find them</cite>. It also innovated early on personalization and community features: <cite index="29-1">a free notification service called "Eyes and Editors" let customers flag favorite authors and receive automatic emails when matching new titles were added, and review pages let customers exchange opinions with people worldwide</cite>.

<cite index="31-1">Amazon's first logo — a snaky, river-like path over a stylized letter "A" on a faux marbled background — remained in place until January 2000, when the company introduced its now-iconic "A to Z" logo</cite>. <cite index="34-1">Later in 1997 Amazon moved on from the gray background of its earliest design</cite>, and by December 1998 — <cite index="34-1">the date of the Wayback Machine's first crawl of the site</cite> — it already looked noticeably more polished.

- **Design language:** Simple left-hand navigation links, minimal graphics, gray background — a modest, catalog-like feel.
- **Core purpose:** Sell books online, backed by search, personalized alerts, and customer reviews.
- **Notable trivia:** Jeff Bezos famously ran the operation out of a rented garage in Seattle in its earliest days.

3. Side-by-Side Comparison

Dimension	Google.com (1998)	Yahoo.com (1996)	Amazon.com (1995)
Primary function	Search	Directory / portal	E-commerce (books, later everything)

Visual style	Extremely minimal, mostly whitespace	Dense text and link lists	Simple sidebar navigation, gray tones, modest graphics
Underlying philosophy	Function over decoration	Comprehensive human-curated navigation	Catalog-style browsing with personalization
Organization	Academic project → startup	Startup portal expanding rapidly	Bootstrapped startup scaling into a retail giant
Logo/branding stability	Changed logo and layout within months	Refreshed branding/design almost annually	Kept its original logo for nearly 5 years before a full 2000 rebrand
How it survives today	Only as a branded nostalgia Easter egg	Only through archive snapshots and retrospectives	Only through archive snapshots and retrospectives
Best represents	The birth of algorithmic search	The rise of the web portal	The birth of e-commerce

4. Key Takeaways

1. **All three grew far beyond their original scope.** Google went from a two-link Stanford page to the dominant search engine; Yahoo expanded from a directory into a sprawling portal; Amazon grew from an online bookstore into a global marketplace for nearly everything.
 2. **Design reflected purpose.** Google's minimalism supported speed and a singular task (search); Yahoo's density supported browsing a directory; Amazon's simple, catalog-like layout supported product discovery and trust-building (via reviews and personalized alerts) in an era when online shopping was new and unproven.
 3. **Infrastructure was primitive by necessity.** All three were built for dial-up-era bandwidth and screen resolutions, explaining the near-total absence of large images or multimedia compared to modern sites.
 4. **None of the three looks anything like it did at launch.** Unlike sites that freeze in time, all three are large, continuously operating businesses — their earliest designs survive only because the Wayback Machine happened to crawl them, not because anyone deliberately preserved them.
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5. Sources

- Web Design Museum — galleries for Google (1998), Yahoo (1996), Amazon (1995 & 1999)
- Version Museum — *31 Years of Amazon.com Website Design History*
- Quartz — *This is what Amazon's homepage looked like when it launched*
- SafeSearchKids — *What Google Looked Like 25 Years Ago*
- Blogoscoped — *Google.com 1997–2011*
- Search Engine Journal — *Yahoo Visual Timeline 1996–2006*

Note: All information above is drawn from publicly available archives and retrospectives; no private or proprietary data was accessed.